Antonino Costa

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Education

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology — Hong Kong, China
Ph.D. in Accounting — September 2022 – June 2027 (Expected)

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology — Hong Kong, China
M.Sc. in Accounting (Accounting Analytics Concentration) — September 2021 – May 2022

Bocconi University — Milan, Italy
B.Sc. in Business Administration and Management — September 2018 – July 2021

Research

Research Interests

Disclosure and Transparency; **Corporate Governance**; **Political Economy**

Job Market Paper

Privacy Concerns and Private Firms' Voluntary Disclosure: Evidence from Mandatory Personal Financial Disclosures (Solo-Authored)

- Presented at the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, the Hong Kong Academic Accounting Association Rookie Camp, and the Chinese University of Hong Kong.
- Committee: Zhihong Chen (Chair), Qingkai Dong, and Arthur Morris

Accepted Paper

The Impact of Municipal-Auditor Appointments on Auditors' Private-Sector Audit Engagements (with Zhihong Chen and Qingkai Dong)
Conditionally accepted, *Journal of Accounting Research*

- Presented at the National University of Singapore*, Singapore Management University*, the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, the 47th EAA Annual Congress, and the 2nd Mediterranean Accounting Conference*.

In Progress

Managerial Experience in the Public Sector and the Trade-Off Between Social and Financial Performance: Evidence from Hospital Manager Appointments (with Zhihong Chen and Qingkai Dong)

* Presented by a coauthor; † Scheduled.

Teaching Experience

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

Course Instructor
Principles of Accounting I (Teaching Evaluation: 4.50/5.00) — Summer 2025

Conferences Attended

HKAAA Junior Accounting Faculty Conference	2026
CAPANA Annual Research Conference	2026
CAPANA Doctoral Consortium	2026
Hawaii Accounting Research Doctoral Institute (HARDI)	2026
Accounting and Economics Society Annual Conference	2025
Accounting and Economics Society Summer School	2025
HKUST Accounting Research Symposium	2022, 2023, 2024, 2025
HKUST Business School PhD Student Conference	2023, 2024, 2025

Honors and Awards

Hong Kong Ph.D. Fellowship Scheme	2022–Present
Beta Gamma Sigma	2023
HKUST RedBird Ph.D. Award	2022
HKUST M.Sc. in Accounting Achievement Scholarship	2022
HKUST M.Sc. in Accounting Admission Half Scholarship	2021

Skills and Professional Activities

Programming	Python, R, SQL, LaTeX
Memberships	European Accounting Association; Accounting and Economics Society
Languages	English (fluent), Italian (native), Putonghua (intermediate), French (intermediate)
Athletics	HKUST Sports Team: Standard Chartered Hong Kong Marathon (2025); Standard Chartered Hong Kong Marathon (Half Marathon) (2024); University Sports Federation of Hong Kong Cross Country Race (2023)

References

Zhihong Chen (Chair)
Associate Professor of Accounting
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Privacy Concerns and Private Firms' Voluntary Disclosure: Evidence from Mandatory Personal Financial Disclosures

Mandatory disclosure of managers' personal financial information can increase the personal informativeness of private firms' financial statements. I examine whether and how this increase in informativeness affects firms' voluntary disclosure by exploiting an Italian mandate requiring local politicians serving in municipalities above a population threshold to publish their personal tax filings. Using a difference-in-differences design, I find that firms managed by politicians subject to the mandate reduce voluntary financial disclosure. Consistent with a privacy-concern mechanism, the reduction is stronger where the joint disclosures are more likely to affect the public's assessment of the politician, where the audience is more attentive, and where the resulting inferences are more likely to be unfavorable. Additional analyses show that the mandate increases media coverage of affected politicians' personal income and is associated with worse electoral outcomes. I find no evidence that firms reduce financial disclosure to conceal rent extraction. Overall, the findings show that greater public exposure of personal information can heighten privacy concerns and discourage voluntary disclosure by private firms.

The Impact of Municipal-Auditor Appointments on Auditors' Private-Sector Audit Engagements

This paper examines how municipal-auditor appointments affect auditors' private-sector audit engagements. Leveraging the lottery-based selection of municipal auditors in Italy, we compare first-time appointees with auditors who have never been appointed. We find that appointed auditors acquire more private clients and expand the geographic reach of their practices, although these clients are not necessarily located closer to the appointing municipalities. These effects are more pronounced for less experienced auditors and in more competitive audit markets. The increase in private clients appears to be primarily driven by greater visibility and networks with other municipal auditors, rather than connections with politicians. We also show that local municipal appointments motivate other auditors to become eligible for future drafts, as evidenced by an increase in new professional registrations. Overall, our findings highlight the role of professional experience gained through municipal-auditor service in shaping labor market outcomes within the auditing profession.

Managerial Experience in the Public Sector and the Trade-Off Between Social and Financial Performance: Evidence from Hospital Manager Appointments

This project examines whether professional requirements for public-sector managers improve organizational performance. We exploit an Italian reform introducing managerial-experience requirements for hospital general managers and study how the reform affects both the characteristics of appointed managers and hospital clinical and financial performance. In particular, we examine whether greater managerial experience shapes the trade-off between financial discipline and clinical outcomes.